

THE THIRD ACCUSED

Nehru cannot be absolved of the responsibility for Partition though he can be exonerated on account of his services to the nation and the world

By MGS NARAYANAN

For India, Independence came on August 15, 1947 as part of a package that included the partition of the British Indian territory on communal lines into India and Pakistan. There was great embarrassment about the unexpected decision to divide, and much suffering due to riots and migrations, but in spite of all that, Freedom at Midnight was celebrated by the majority of survivors on this side of the fence. Only Gandhi who had done his best to avoid the catastrophe of Partition anticipated the troubles that were to follow and offered penance by fasting in a remote village of West Bengal and refusing to go to the capital for tasting Independence. Many people wanted to overcome the shock of Partition by stopping to think about it, by pushing it down memory lane.

Soon after Independence, people were not inclined to go deep into the causes and circumstances of Partition, partly because I suspect they were vaguely afraid of identifying the guilt or the complicity of some of their favourite national leaders. They were pre-occupied with other concerns like restoring peace and friendship, creating democratic constitutional machinery, reorganising the administration, redrawing state boundaries, and developing agriculture and industry.

Partition certainly appeared to be a serious crime to many patriotic people who were trained to worship Mother India. It was seen not merely as a political blunder, but as an act of sacrilege. Was it a case of political rape of the mother which, like many such cases, revealed an element of consent and surrender, the choice of survival as against annihilation? The champions of unity and secularism temporarily closed their eyes towards the reality of the birth of a rogue state as the offspring, vitiating all

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JINNAH (RIGHT) WAS NO CONSERVATIVE MUSLIM

Jinnah's jealousy of Jawaharlal Nehru made him choose a suicidal course which he seems to have regretted at the fag end of his life.



community relations in the subcontinent, and put the seal of their consent on Partition. How were they made to buy the hated British idea of a communal division of India? Why did they agree to a crude surgical operation without anaesthesia on a healthy body on the basis of a laboriously manufactured consent? As in any political drama there certainly was much activity behind the scenes, even behind the conscious layers of the mind of the actors involved, in the course of the prolonged parleys within closed doors, dinners and tiresome negotiations with intervals in which the prince charming was allegedly flirting with the princess.